

UGS 303

Identity, Community & Development

Fall 2026 / Course syllabus

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Term: August 24, 2026 - December 10, 2026

Meetings: Tue / Thu 9:30-10:45 AM in CAL 100

Office hours: Tuesday 2-4 PM in CAL 214

Tutoring: Wednesday at 6 PM in Learning Commons

Course Overview

How does a sense of self take shape in relation to other people? This seminar brings developmental research into conversation with literature, public space and ordinary experience. We will consider identity as an ongoing process, paying particular attention to the communities that make certain stories possible and others difficult to tell.

Key Dates

September 18, 2026 | Observation #2 due

October 14, 2026 at 9:30 AM | Midterm

November 12, 2026 | Project proposal due

December 8, 2026 | Final project due

Reading, observation & conversation

Working together

Our classroom is a place to practice careful attention. Productive disagreement depends on representing another person's view fairly before responding. The texts invite different interpretations, and discussion will be strongest when those interpretations are connected to particular passages or observations. Curiosity matters more than the performance of certainty.

Writing in this course develops through revision. Early observations can be tentative, specific and incomplete. As a project grows, students should make the relationship between evidence and interpretation more visible. Feedback describes what a reader can follow, where a question remains and what further evidence could help.

Weekly Schedule

- Week 1 Self, story and the social world
- Week 2 Attention and everyday observation
- Week 3 Families and inherited narratives
- Week 4 Community boundaries and belonging
- Week 5 Language, memory and identity
- Week 6 Development across contexts
- Week 7 Institutions and public space
- Week 8 Revisiting our questions
- Week 9 Field observations and interpretation
- Week 10 The ethics of representing others
- Week 11 From observation to argument
- Week 12 Workshop conversations
- Week 13 Revision and synthesis
- Week 14 Sharing perspectives

Assessment & course resources

Assessment philosophy

Assessment emphasizes the clarity of an argument, the care of its evidence and the thoughtfulness of revision. An ambitious question is valuable even when its answer remains open. Strong work acknowledges the limits of an observation and distinguishes a claim from an impression. Grades reflect the development of these practices across the semester.

Observation #2 due September 18, 2026

The observation portfolio draws on ordinary settings such as a campus path, a shared kitchen or a public gathering. Descriptions should protect the privacy of people encountered. Names and identifying details are generally unnecessary for explaining a social pattern.

Course Resources

Canvas: <https://canvas.example.edu/courses/ugs303>

Canvas contains readings, assignment descriptions and the full course bibliography. The website is a shared reference shelf for the seminar. Office hours offer space for questions about a reading, a draft or an idea that does not yet have a clear shape. The weekly tutoring session provides an additional setting for conversation.

Access and participation

People contribute in different ways. Listening carefully, connecting ideas and making space for another speaker all support the work of the group. Course materials are organized with clear headings and readable formats. Students may discuss access needs privately with the instructor so that classroom participation can be planned thoughtfully.

Academic integrity

The distinction between one's own interpretation and the work of others should remain visible. Quotation, paraphrase and borrowed ideas all need appropriate attribution. The purpose of citation is to make an intellectual conversation traceable, giving readers a path back to the materials that shaped an argument.

Policies & grading

Extensions and communication

Requests must be submitted at least one week in advance. Extensions may be granted for documented circumstances. Late work may receive reduced credit. Students should contact the professor if they need accommodations. These policies explain the process; they are not individual assignments.

We aim to respond to emails if received on weekdays; sometimes delays occur due to other commitments. Email response times are not assignment deadlines.

Grading overview

Canvas quizzes - 5%

Participation - 10%

Observation portfolio - 25%

Midterm - 20%

Final project - 40%

The final grade is based on the assessments above. Submit work through Canvas using the dates listed in Key Dates. This table describes weights, not additional deliverables.